HIMANTA, THE NEW HINDU CHAMP

The Assam chief minister's polarising narrative, which ties the preservation of Assamese culture to Hindu identity, is increasingly shaping the political landscape in his state and deepening the societal divide

By KAUSHIK DEKA

Two weeks after the nation was shaken by the brutal rape and murder of a trainee doctor in Kolkata, another horrific crime—the gang rape of a 14-year-old girl in Assam—captured headlines. Unlike the Kolkata case, which stirred up controversy amid accusations of an official cover-up, the incident in Nagaon's Dhing, about 100 km from state capital Guwahati, is drawing attention as a symptom of the deepening socio-political divide in the state.

The prime suspect in the Dhing case was arrested within 24 hours, only to drown in a pond, allegedly while attempting to escape police custody. On the same day, in an unrelated but eerily similar incident, a man accused of molestation was shot by police while trying to flee in Tezpur. These incidents highlight a troubling pattern that has emerged since Himanta Biswa Sarma took office as Assam's chief minister in 2021. In cases involving rape, drug trafficking or other serious crimes, suspects—often of Muslim origin—have frequently died under contentious circumstances while in police custody.

Instead of questioning the role of law enforcement in these deaths, many in Assam have praised them as examples of swift justice. Sarma, while defending his administration's "prompt handling of rape cases", has tacitly endorsed this approach as a means to reduce crimes against women. Since he became CM, the number of reported rapes in the state has nearly halved—from 1,779 in 2021 to



JUSTICE, HIMANTA-STYLE CM Sarma speaking to the media in Guwahati, Aug. 21

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